Heart Disease

Medical Overview, Warning Signs, Risk Factors, Diagnosis & Prevention

Quick summary: Heart disease refers to several conditions that affect the heart or blood vessels. Coronary artery disease is one of the most common forms. Recognizing warning signs and addressing cardiovascular risk factors can help reduce serious complications.

1. What Is Heart Disease?

Heart disease is a broad term for conditions affecting the heart's structure, muscle, rhythm, valves, or blood supply. Some conditions develop gradually, while others can cause sudden symptoms and require urgent medical attention.

2. Common Types of Heart Conditions

Condition	Description
Coronary Artery Disease	Narrowing or blockage of the coronary arteries, often related to plaque buildup, which can reduce blood flow to the heart muscle.
Heart Arrhythmias	Abnormal heart rhythms that may be too fast, too slow, or irregular.
Heart Failure	A condition in which the heart cannot pump blood as effectively as the body needs.
Valvular Heart Disease	Problems involving one or more heart valves, including narrowing or leakage.
Cardiomyopathy	Disease of the heart muscle that can affect its ability to pump or maintain a normal rhythm.

3. Common Warning Signs & Symptoms

- Chest pain, pressure, tightness, or discomfort
- Shortness of breath
- Unusual fatigue
- Dizziness or lightheadedness
- Fainting or near-fainting
- Palpitations or an unusually rapid or irregular heartbeat
- Pain or discomfort spreading to the arm, shoulder, back, neck, or jaw
- Swelling of the legs, ankles, or feet

■ WHEN TO SEEK URGENT HELP

Seek emergency medical help immediately if symptoms suggestive of a heart attack occur, particularly chest pressure or discomfort that is severe, persistent, or accompanied by shortness of breath, sweating, nausea, fainting, or pain spreading to the arm, shoulder, back, neck, or jaw. Do not delay emergency care while trying to determine the cause.

4. Key Risk Factors

Modifiable Factors	Non-Modifiable / Less Modifiable Factors
• High blood pressure • High cholesterol • Smoking and tobacco use • Diabetes or impaired glucose control • Physical inactivity • Overweight or obesity • Unhealthy diet • Excessive alcohol consumption	• Increasing age • Family history • Genetic factors • Previous cardiovascular disease • Certain inherited conditions

5. Diagnosis & Medical Evaluation

The appropriate evaluation depends on the person's symptoms, medical history, physical examination, and cardiovascular risk.

Test / Evaluation	Purpose
ECG / EKG	Records the heart's electrical activity.
Echocardiogram	Uses ultrasound to assess heart structure and function.
Stress testing	Evaluates heart function during controlled physical or medication-induced stress.
Blood tests	May include cholesterol, glucose, cardiac biomarkers, and other tests when appropriate.
Coronary imaging	CT coronary angiography or invasive coronary angiography may be used when clinically indicated.

6. Prevention & Heart-Healthy Habits

- Eat a balanced diet rich in vegetables, fruits, whole grains, legumes, and other minimally processed foods.
- Limit excessive saturated fat, trans fat, sodium, and highly processed foods.
- Aim for regular physical activity appropriate for your health and fitness level.
- Avoid smoking and tobacco products.
- Maintain healthy blood pressure, cholesterol, and blood glucose levels.
- Maintain a healthy body weight where appropriate.
- Get recommended health screenings and discuss cardiovascular risk with a healthcare professional.
- Manage sleep, stress, and other lifestyle factors that affect cardiovascular health.

7. When to Contact a Healthcare Professional

Discuss new, unexplained, recurring, or worsening symptoms with a qualified healthcare professional. Medical evaluation is particularly important when symptoms occur with exertion, are associated with fainting or significant breathlessness, or occur in someone with known cardiovascular risk factors.

Medical disclaimer: This document provides general educational information and is not a substitute for professional medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment. Symptoms can have many causes, and individual medical decisions should be made with a qualified healthcare professional. If you believe you may be experiencing a medical emergency, seek emergency medical care.